



Figure 15: A redesigned Qt4 version of YaST2 UI

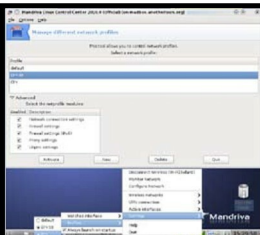


Figure 16: Network profiles are a life saver when you're on the move

open a terminal, run `sudo modprobe nvidia`, log out and back in to X, and you are done.) Simple.

And in openSUSE, you need a Web browser. Head to <http://en.opensuse.org/NVIDIA> or <http://en.opensuse.org/ATI> and then use the one-click feature to install the driver. Simple again!

|          |                |
|----------|----------------|
| The Good | Mandriva 2010  |
| The Bad  | (K)Ubuntu 9.10 |
| The Ugly | openSUSE 11.2  |

## Criteria 6: Package manager

Ubuntu uses DEB packages, while Mandriva and openSUSE use RPM. For those not familiar with these terms, DEB is an unparalleled package management system that just has no match. Need I say more?

Yes. Between the two, I found *zypper* easier to use compared to *urpmi*, as the former's options to install and remove packages are similar to that of *apt-get*. Besides, *zypper* includes an option to download all RPMs before installing them. However, it's not enabled by default, and you must edit the `/etc/zypp/zypp.conf` file and add the following line under the relevant section:

```
commit.downloadMode=DownloadInAdvance
```

That should do the trick!

|                 |                |
|-----------------|----------------|
| The (very) Good | (K)Ubuntu 9.10 |
| The Bad         | openSUSE 11.2  |
| The Ugly        | Mandriva 2010  |

## Criteria 7: Config centres

Mandriva has something called the Mandriva Control Centre (Figure 14). Windows users, who have Control

Panel, will finally say Linux has a match in the Control Centre department. From MCC, one can administer every aspect of the system, including, but not limited to, adding/removing software, administering hardware, networks, printing, the boot process, user accounts, the look and feel, and a lot more. And it's neatly categorised with a very slick UI.

OpenSUSE, on the other hand, has YaST!, or Yet Another Setup Tool! (it has an exclamation mark at the end). As you can see in Figure 15, this one is also cleverly designed and a bit more powerful than MCC. However, this is at the cost of user friendliness.

Oh, and Ubuntu and its brothers have no configuration centres at all.

|          |                |
|----------|----------------|
| The Good | Mandriva 2010  |
| The Bad  | openSUSE 11.2  |
| The Ugly | (K)Ubuntu 9.10 |

## Criteria 8: Customisation, unique features, the 'X' factor, and our beloved bugs

Let's start with dialogue boxes. In openSUSE, applications like Firefox, OpenOffice.Org and others like Thunderbird use KDE4 and GNOME dialogue boxes for Save/Open dialogues based on the DE they are running under. This happens in Ubuntu as well, but not in Mandriva.

openSUSE, as usual, seems to be housing some bizarre bugs. While running under KDE4, OpenOffice.org apps seemed to have no Status Bar; however, randomly clicking in that area did make indicators like `INSRT/OVR` appear. And back when I first installed and started openSUSE, it froze up for no reason at all. Switching to a text console and running `top` seemed to suggest that Beagle Desktop Search was using up a lot of processing resources. The HDD data activity indicator